

Collaborative Learning in Distributed Teams: A Field Study

Trang Nguyen & Pablo Alvarez — International Journal of Organizational Behaviour, 2023

1. Introduction

Distributed teams have become commonplace in contemporary organizations. Understanding how team members create and maintain shared understanding across distance remains an open question for organizational research.

Knowledge sharing is defined as the process by which individuals exchange work-related expertise, skills and insights with their colleagues (Brock et al., 2005).

We assessed knowledge sharing using a six-item scale adapted from Reychan and Hung (2015). Items such as "I share my expertise with other team members" were rated on a seven-point scale ranging from 1 (never) to 7 (always).

Prior studies link collaborative learning behaviors with performance and with reduced coordination costs in distributed settings (Wong and Singh, 2021).

2. Theoretical background

An alternative tradition treats the same phenomenon as knowledge exchange refers to the process through which individuals transfer work-related expertise, skills and insights to their colleagues.

Knowledge exchange was measured with a five-item scale. Items such as "Colleagues often share their knowledge with me" were completed by 92 software engineers in a cross-sectional survey.

Following Ritchie (2019), team cohesion is defined here as the ratio of task interdependence to interpersonal conflict within a work team, computed from quarterly collaboration metrics.

This operationalization differs from earlier survey-based approaches and is included to examine metric-driven team analytics.

3. Method and results

Team cohesion refers to the degree of mutual commitment, trust and bonding that holds a work team together (Mullen and Copper, 1994).

Team cohesion was assessed using a four-item scale. Items such as "Members of this team pull together" were rated by 92 employees on a five-point Likert scale. Cronbach alpha was .87.

Knowledge sharing correlated positively with team cohesion ($r = .41$, $p < .01$) and with self-rated performance ($r = .29$, $p < .05$).

4. Limitations

The cross-sectional design, single-source ratings and concentration of participants in one industry limit causal claims. Future research should employ longitudinal designs and objective performance records.